

69.1 Lands Claimed by Louis of Bavaria

Nicholas V fled the city, aware that in his patron's absence, the goodwill of the people of Rome would not give him claim over the Christian church in Italy, let alone the world. Instead, he made his way to Avignon and asked John XXII for absolution. John XXII granted it, and Nicholas V faded gratefully into obscurity.

So far, honors in the struggle between pope and emperor were about even. But John XXII now made a theological misstep. In Avignon, on November 1, 1331, he preached a sermon giving a new interpretation of the Beatific Vision, the direct vision of God given to the righteous dead, who were traditionally thought of as being in the presence of God. Instead, the pope taught, they were in an intermediate state; protected by Christ, free from human woes, but still not in the direct presence of God. Not until the Last Judgment, the setting of all things right, would the faithful actually *see* God.[10]

The sermon was preached on All Saints' Day, when the church celebrated those who had finished the race of life and now lived on the other shore. To suggest that those faithful dead were *still* waiting, blocked from the presence